B1 Reading

Finding the main idea: topic sentences

Find what each paragraph is about by spotting its topic sentence, and tell main ideas from supporting details.

Most paragraphs in articles and textbooks have one main idea. It is usually stated in a *topic sentence*, often the first sentence. The other sentences give examples, reasons or details that support it.

Part	What it does	Clue words
Topic sentence	States the main idea	*Many people..., There are several reasons..., The main problem is...*
Supporting details	Examples, reasons, facts	*for example, for instance, because, also, such as*
Concluding sentence	Repeats or sums up the idea	*So, In short, That's why...*

Ask "what is the whole paragraph about?" The main idea must cover every sentence. If your answer only fits one sentence, it is a detail, not the main idea.

Common mistake. Choosing an answer just because it uses the same words as the text. Exam options often repeat words from one detail to trap you.

Read the text

Cycling to work has many benefits. First, it is good for your health, because you exercise every day without going to the gym. It is also cheap: you don't pay for petrol or parking. In many cities, it is even faster than driving, especially in the rush hour. That's why more and more people are leaving their cars at home.

Practice

1. What is the topic sentence?
2. Which is the main idea? (a) Petrol is expensive. (b) Cycling to work has advantages. (c) Driving is slow in the rush hour.
3. Give one supporting detail about money.
4. Which word introduces the second benefit?
5. Which is the concluding sentence?

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. Cycling to work has many benefits.
2. (b)
3. You don't pay for petrol or parking.
4. also
5. That's why more and more people are leaving their cars at home.